

Episode 52: Once Upon a Time... (33) – *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* Starts

A typhoon is approaching!

The Tokyo area was stormed by howling winds all night long, and it's still rough this morning. When I was a child, I loved going outside in this kind of weather wearing a raincoat (or rather, rain cape) and rubber boots (laugh).

Recently, I often see women wearing rubber boots on the streets and trains on rainy days.

But these aren't just any rubber boots—they're the slightly cool outdoor-type ones from a certain company. The women cleverly match them boot-style with their clothes. It looks really stylish and good. So I wonder, "What would it be like if a man wore these?" Yes, naturally I'm wanting to try them myself (laugh) > outdoor-type rubber boots.

So I researched various options on the manufacturer's website. Oh! There they were—cool men's (or rather, unisex) ones. Hmm. I unconsciously entered fantasy mode with visions floating above my head (laugh). Imagining myself looking perfectly sharp... yes! Decision made!

But here's the thing! My feet are actually quite large. So when I checked sizes, as expected, I'd need the largest size. And...

Hmm, the web site's online shop was out of stock. I wonder about their direct shops? Do they even carry them? (sweat)

Will I be able to intercept this year's rainy season with cool outdoor rubber boots? (laugh)

By the way, today's manuscript is apparently episode 52. 52 episodes means exactly 4 cours for TV anime, exactly one year at 52 weeks. Well, for these "Colour Design Notes," I've taken breaks sometimes—or rather, frequently—so it's been well over a year since serialisation started, but somehow for "anime industry work," 52 feels like a good milestone, so I'm having a little solo celebration (laugh).

Well then.

Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2: Lonely Cats Battle Royal, Vampire War, and Crying Freeman 4: Yugekitougoku, Crying Freeman 5: Senjou no Kishimojin. I've been writing about the OVA cycle from 1990 onwards, but actually a big project was running in parallel. An OVA series no less! A full 13 episodes! *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* (天上編 宇宙皇子).

Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji - Original by Fujikawa Keisuke, character design concept by Inomata Mutsumi, character design & chief animation director Yamazaki Nobuyoshi, art director Matsumoto Kenji, director Imazawa Tetsuo. Production by Kadokawa Shoten. An anime adaptation of Fujikawa Keisuke's SF (?) epic novel series "Uchuu Kouji," which could be called his life's work.

The previous year (1989), also produced by Kadokawa Shoten, theatrical *Uchuu Kouji* was released (animation production by Trans Arts), which was an adaptation of the "Earth Chapter." So this time was an adaptation of the sequel "Heaven Chapter."

Even though it was an OVA, unlike the Toei Video OVAs I was participating in simultaneously, it was basically TV format 30-minute episodes. With exactly 13 episodes = 1 cour series, it was sized to be broadcast on TV as-is.

The recognition around this was somewhat delicate (laugh). As a company (Toei Doga), the thinking was "Since it's the same length as TV, just make it quickly with TV-level quality," but we field creators thought "It's an OVA and the length is TV-short, so let's put in maximum effort!" (laugh). Well, it's a perfectly natural flow (laugh).

I think about 2 months of production time was allocated per episode, but maybe we worked too hard and took too much time, resulting in 2 months (bitter laugh). The flow was that staff for the next episode would see the rushes or first print of preceding episodes and think "Alright, let's work hard to make something even better!" (laugh). So each episode became progressively more substantial.

For this series, I handled character colour design and colour direction & inspection for each episode. During this period, I was doubling up with Toei Video OVAs, but since those were mostly hard "realistic" works, doubling with *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji*, which felt like a work with a somewhat different, softer atmosphere, was a good balance for me.

I already had a strong tendency to get emotionally involved and absorbed in work, but this production had attractive circumstances beyond content. This *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* series was going to be released on LaserDisc!

While LaserDisc (LD hereafter) is now a relic of the past, the feeling at the time was that it was a "digital" high-quality medium. While VHS or Beta videotape images deteriorated over time, images stored on LD could be reproduced beautifully semi-permanently. It was truly an attractive medium.

Around this time, a new recording/playback format for music, MD (MiniDisk), also appeared, and "digital" technology was gradually becoming mainstream. Well, MD is still alive, but we never imagined that LD would meet such an abrupt end with hardware and all through "the rise of DVD" (bitter laugh).

Now then.

I knew "Uchuu Kouji" was a popular original work, but I had never read it myself, so before starting actual production work, I recklessly thought "First, let me try reading through the original?" and bought all the paperback volumes at once with a "ba-dump!"

(By coincidence, I ran into Sato Jun'ichi at that bookstore! Seeing my bulk purchase of paperbacks, he laughed hard saying "I've never seen anyone buy books like this!" (laugh)).

So I eagerly started reading volume 1 of the "Earth Chapter"...

Ah, I failed spectacularly (explosion). In the end, I never reached the crucial "Heaven Chapter," and the days of OVA *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* began (laugh).

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